

[Return to Search](#)

The Azande: history and political institutions

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'That son of mine, you have made a love-bond with him!' 'Oh, no master!' 'Yes you have, you are merely mocking me. That son of mine who is always in the outer court, what is he always waiting for? He has a lover among you.' 'O master how you joke with us.' [Prince Ngere calls one of his small pages and says] 'This boy is your lover!' 'Oh no master, if it were indeed thus how would we escape your anger and live?' 'Hm, come here and draw beer for me.' One of the young women brings him a gourdful of beer from which he drinks, afterwards handing back the gourd to her with a playful tap.

124
[Interviewing In Research](#)

521
[Conversation](#)

595
[Polygamy](#)

643
[Chief Executive](#)

644
[Executive Household](#)

I do not know how typical such a conversation piece would have been. Ngere was regarded as eccentric. A prince slept with whichever of his wives he pleased, and there was not the same need for him to serve all his wives in turn as there was with the commoners. But he chiefly had congress with his favourites. Azande say that a prince sits naked in his hut with his favourites, also naked, playing with them and drinking beer. They say he would have relations with one of them, then drink beer for a time, then have relations with another, then drink more beer. As princes in the past did no work they had nothing much else to do in their private quarters except to drink beer, talk to their wives, and have their pleasure of them. These favourites slept together in a hut or, if there were many of them, in two huts, near their master's hut; but

174
[Historical Reconstruction](#)

595
[Polygamy](#)

644
[Executive Household](#)

833
[Sexual Intercourse](#)

when they had children they became *adengbanga*, wives of the court, and had their own separate homesteads.

The *negbindi* was the king's cook. He was always scared lest one of his wives put medicines in his food, so he consulted the poison oracle to determine which of his wives would be a safe cook for him, and he ate no food other than that prepared by her. She enjoyed great respect in the royal household and had one or two slave-girls placed at her disposal to grind grain and fetch water and firewood for her. A Zande said: 'A prince did not eat food prepared by his many wives, only by that wife about whom he had consulted the poison oracle, saying to it, "If that wife prepares food for me to eat, will she make some trickery with my food?" If the oracle replied "No" the prince stuck to her alone, she always prepared his food; but all the other wives prepared food for the prince's subjects.' In Gbudwe's home each queen also had a *negbindi* whose duty it was to cook the food sent by her mistress into court, and servants and slaves were put at her disposal, for these cooks were *aboro ilisa*, 'esteemed persons'.

174

Historical
Reconstruction

252

Food Preparation

595

Polygamy

644

Executive Household

787

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